

Chapter 15

Closing a Session or Group

Two kinds of closing are discussed in this chapter: the closing of a session and the closing of the entire series of sessions. The *closing phase* is the period of a session when the leader wraps things up. The *closing stage* may be the last session of the group or the last few sessions, depending on the kind of group and the total number of sessions involved.

The Closing Phase

Every session should have a closing phase. The length of the closing phase will depend on both the length of the session and the kind of group being led. For a longer session, more time is usually required. For a 1-hour session, the leader may find 3 to 5 minutes sufficient; a 2- to 3-hour session may require 5 to 10 minutes for the closing phase. The closing phase of a discussion or task group may simply be summarizing the main ideas or decisions made. Because this is fairly straightforward, less time is required. In a support or therapy group where members share a range of thoughts and feelings, more time is required to pull together key points, clarify goals, check for unfinished business, and encourage reactions. With experience, the leader learns to judge the amount of time needed to bring closure to the session.

During the closing phase, the leader has the opportunity to encourage members to share their thoughts and feelings about the session. Members may share how they benefited from activities or discussion that occurred during the session. It is especially important for the leader to hear from those members who were less verbal in the session. The leader can benefit from hearing how they feel about what is taking place and whether they are feeling comfortable. Also, less

active members may be perceived negatively, and their sharing can help link them to the group, causing other members to gain some better understanding of who they are and how they are experiencing the group.

It is important to inform the members that the session is entering the closing phase. This can be done by saying any of the following:

- We need to start winding down, so I want you to think about the session today, and what it has meant to you.
- Because there are only a few minutes left in today's session, let's review what we have gone over today.
- I think we are at a good stopping point, so let's spend the next few minutes summarizing the session today, and then we'll talk briefly about next week's session.
- Let's begin the closing phase of the session, because we need to stop in about 10 minutes.

Purposes and Goals of the Closing Phase

The closing phase may serve one or more of the following purposes: (1) summarizing and highlighting the main points, (2) reinforcing commitments made by individual members, and (3) checking for unfinished business from the session.

Summarizing and Highlighting the Main Points One purpose of the closing phase is to pull the session together by highlighting and summarizing important points. Pulling together salient points or experiences helps members remember them after the session has ended; the impact of the session can thus be increased. Having the group focus on key points also gives members a chance to hear what was important to others. This sharing often tends to build greater trust and cohesiveness among members.

Reinforcing Commitments In many groups, members may commit to some task or change in their behavior. Reviewing such commitments in the closing phase is valuable. The following two examples show how a leader might clarify goals and strengthen commitments.

EXAMPLES

It is the end of the second session of a task group made up of members who work at a mental health agency. Their task is to develop a new residential program for adolescents.

LEADER: Let's review who is to do what. Joe, what are you going to do before the next meeting?

JOE: I am going to call those two agencies that have residential programs and find out what problems they have had.

LEADER: Good. See if they'll send you any material, too.

PABLO: I am going to draw up a tentative list of rules for the unit residents to live by.

LEADER: Be sure to get input from us, especially from Cindy.

CINDY: I am going to devise a list of personnel that would be needed to staff such a unit.

BILL: I'm going to try to get funding for the unit.

LEADER: Bill, I think we decided that you were to look into possible sources for funding and bring that list to the group next session.



It is the third session of a therapy group. Members have shared a variety of concerns during the session, and the leader wishes to clarify members' goals and reinforce their commitments to those goals.

LEADER: Each of you in today's session has expressed a desire to change an aspect of your life. Three or four of you worked on specific goals you want to follow through on before our next meeting. As we close today, let's take a few minutes to briefly hear from each of you about your goals.

CHANG: I want to go home this weekend and not fight with my mother.

LEADER: You sound pretty committed to that, Chang. I'd like to suggest you keep notes and report back to us on how that works. *(Chang nods.)* Who else feels they might try something different this week? *(Looks around at the group)*

JOHN: Well, I know I've got to do something about staying out so late.

LEADER: What did you decide as a result of discussing it here today?

JOHN: I am going to ask my wife which days are better for me to stay out late.

LEADER: Didn't you also say that first you have to see if she will agree to let you stay out at least two nights and that you are going to ask her if she would like to come with you?

JOHN: That's right! I forgot that part, and it's important. I'll talk to her and really try to be open with her.



In both of these examples, the leader increases the likelihood that the members will follow through on their commitments. A good closing phase is necessary to review and clarify decisions made during the working phase of the session. As in the preceding and following examples, the interaction may often be leader–member–leader–member in the closing phase, which is fine. You would not want to do this during the middle phase of a session, but it is appropriate during the closing phase. Sometimes members make commitments and plans that are

unrealistic. Reviewing various members' commitments and plans during the closing phase allows unrealistic goals to be clarified. The following are two examples of a leader helping a member modify an unrealistic goal.

EXAMPLES

It is the third session of a personal growth group in a college counseling center. During the closing phase of the session, the leader asks various members about their goals.

LEADER: I think we've summarized what we covered today pretty well. In the next few minutes, it might be helpful if people share specific goals that they are shooting for this week. Betty, I know you decided to try a different approach with your boyfriend when he's late.

BETTY: Today I learned that yelling only gets us into a fight. When he is late, I'm going to calmly tell him that I'm disappointed and that I'm willing to wait for only 20 minutes. I feel better knowing I can be in control.

LEADER: Frieda, how about you? You said you wanted to set up a study schedule. Have you come up with any thoughts about how you might do that?

FRIEDA: I decided I'm going to study 6 hours every night. That should really help me catch up.

LEADER: *(Turning to the other members)* What do you think about Frieda's plan?

WILL: That seems like a lot. I'd get burned out in one day. *(Other members nod agreement.)*

LEADER: What do you think, Frieda?

FRIEDA: Well, maybe that is a lot. I guess I'll start with 2 hours and see how that goes. Anything will be an improvement.

By helping the member develop a realistic goal, the leader has increased the likelihood of the member experiencing success.

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During the session, Al discussed his desire for a salary increase. With the help of the group, he role-played strategies for talking with his employer about the raise. Although he made progress, Al needed further assistance in increasing his assertiveness and in exploring ways to handle potential rebuffs and excuses from his boss. The group is now in the closing phase.

LEADER: Who else learned something from today's session?

AL: Boy, I did. That role-playing about asking for a raise really helped. Even though you don't think I am ready, I do. I think I'll go in tomorrow and ask for the raise!

LEADER: Al, if he says no, what are you going to say? We didn't get a chance to practice that.

AL: Oh, I didn't even think of that. All I was thinking about was how I now know what to say. I'm not prepared for a negative answer. Maybe I should wait until we talk about it next week in group.

If the leader had not clarified the member's goal during the closing phase, Al would probably have asked for a raise even though he had not developed the resources to cope with the situation. By reviewing Al's reaction to the session, the leader was able to discover his unrealistic plan and caution him about moving ahead prematurely.

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Checking for Unresolved Issues (Unfinished Business) The closing phase is also the time to check with members for any issues that are not fully resolved during the session. Sometimes issues are brought up that may need some additional closure as the session comes to an end. The leader may find it unproductive to focus for too long on a particular member or issue and thus bring temporary closure to the discussion. The closing phase may be used to refocus on that previous issue or concern, providing an opportunity for a member to express new thoughts or for the leader to help members agree to continue to work on the issue in the next session. This would be especially important if there was some tension between members regarding something that happened during the session. Occasionally, a member may have unfinished business that cannot wait until the following session, either because a decision is imminent or because the issue is causing considerable discomfort for the member. The leader could ask the members if they would be willing to extend the session to work on the issue. If this cannot be done, the leader may see the member individually as soon after the session as possible.

To find out if members have unfinished business from the session, the leader can say something like the following:

- Does anyone have something that was "stirred up" during the session that they want to mention? We'll either deal with it now, if it won't take too long, or we will deal with it at the next session.
- Is there any unfinished business from the session that you think needs to be discussed for a few minutes?
- I want to come back to what happened earlier and make sure everyone is in a reasonably good place before we finished the session.

Because there are time constraints during the closing phase, the leader may need to carry unfinished business into the next session. However, by having members mention their unfinished business, the leader is able to either help them finish the issue or assure them that they will be able to discuss the matter at the next session.

EXAMPLES

During a counseling group at a rehabilitation center, Troy expressed some angry feelings regarding his parents' not visiting him often enough, but he was not able to see how he was upsetting himself by blaming his parents. After working with Troy for about 20 minutes, the leader chose to focus on another member. Now, during the closing phase, the leader wants to see if Troy has had any additional thoughts about his anger toward his parents.

LEADER: We'll spend the next few minutes bringing things to a close for today. I'd like each of you to think about what stood out for you. *(Pauses and scans the group. After a short silence, the leader makes eye contact with Troy.)* Troy, I felt there were more feelings you had to express about your parents. While we don't have time to work a lot more with those feelings today, do you have additional thoughts you would like to share with the group?

TROY: I feel better after talking about it, but I still think they should visit more. I don't seem as angry.

LEADER: I guess I'd like you to keep thinking about this between now and our next session. I hope you'll bring it up at the next session. *(Troy nods in agreement.)*

Here the leader contracts with the member to work on the issue during the next session. He wants to make it clear to the member and the entire group that he is not forgetting the issue and plans to come back to it. He also wants to make sure that if there are any pressing feelings, they are handled before the session ends.

A group of divorced men and women are meeting for the fourth session in a support/therapy group. One member, Ann, worked on guilt feelings about giving the custody of her two children to her husband. During the session, Ann concluded that she did not have to feel guilty about her actions. However, when the focus of the group shifted to another topic, Ann continued to think about her decision. Now the leader is bringing the group to a close.

LEADER: Several of you worked on some pretty important issues today. It might be useful to review our session and see if you have additional thoughts about anything you discussed.

SUE: It was really helpful for me to see that even though my parents don't believe in divorce, that's their value and it's okay for me to have a different value.

LEADER: I'm glad that helped, Sue. What about other people?

ANN: *(Looking down and speaking in a weak voice)* I've been sitting here thinking about my kids. I know being without them right now is best for me. Yet, to be a good mother, I still feel I should be with them. I guess I'm confused all over again.

LEADER: Ann, it is apparent there is more we need to do to help clear up your concerns. Can this wait until our next session?

ANN: I think it can wait. I have to get this straight in my mind.

Had the leader not checked for unfinished business, Ann might have felt stranded with those feelings when she left the group. Also, the leader could have finished the session thinking that Ann had worked through a personal issue when, in fact, she was still struggling with it.

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Formats for Closing a Session

There are several formats that can be used for closing a session. The choice of format for a particular session should depend on the kind of group, the purpose of the particular session, and what occurred during the session. To close a session, leaders can use rounds, dyads, written reactions, or have the members summarize. The leader may want to vary the closings of different sessions. In a discussion, education, or task group, it may not be important for each member to speak during the closing phase, because members have shared ideas and thoughts rather than personal feelings. In support, personal growth, counseling, and therapy groups, it is usually valuable for members to share their reactions and feelings about the session.

Rounds Eliciting brief comments from members about what they learned or what stood out as they think back on the session is an excellent way to close a session. We most frequently use a round or series of rounds. The round encourages those who have talked less during the session to share their reactions. When setting up a round, the leader should instruct the members to limit their comments to a sentence or two. Longer responses defeat the purpose of the closing round, which is to highlight important points for each member.

■ EXAMPLE

LEADER: In a sentence or two, what will you take away from the session today? *(Pause)* Tim, let's start with you.

TIM: I learned that I am more non-assertive than assertive.

GUILLERMO: I learned that it is hard for me to be assertive. I guess I'm chicken.

LEADER: I wouldn't say chicken. You simply have not learned to be assertive.

BILL: I learned that my parents are the cause of my being so aggressive.

LEADER: Bill, let me clarify that for you and everyone here. We learn things from what our parents do and say. Often we tend to act like them unless we pay attention to our behavior. *(Turns to Bill)* In your case,

from what you described, your parents are very aggressive. However, this does not mean you have to be aggressive, but you probably will be unless you monitor yourself. I hope the group will be a big help to you.

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GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Closing a Group–Use of Rounds

Go to video 15.1 and watch the segment where the leader uses a round to close the group.

Dyads Followed by Comments to the Group Starting the closing phase with dyads is a good way to involve all the members. Dyads are beneficial during the closing phase when much has happened in the group and the leader wants members to get a chance to share but does not have the time to hear all that each member has to say. In dyads, members can say out loud to another their thoughts and feelings. Dyads can also be used to energize members, especially if the energy level is low toward the end of a session.

■ EXAMPLES

LEADER: Let's take the next few minutes to close. I'd like to form pairs composed of Phil and Pat; Roger and Paula; Ted and Ramón; Mike and Kay. What I'd like you to do is share with your partner one or two things that were particularly important to you about today's session. Then we'll come back to the large group and share any thoughts and feelings.

In this example, the leader decided to pair the members, but she could have allowed the members to select partners. If the leader decides to do the pairing, she should give special thought to anything that occurred during the session that might make it especially valuable for certain members to be together; for example, two members who expressed similar concerns or worked on similar problems could be paired. In the following example, the leader decides to participate in a dyad to encourage a member to share during the closing phase.

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It is the second session of a support group made up of spouses of alcoholics. One member, Sally, has spoken only a couple of times during these first two sessions.

LEADER: As we're closing tonight, I'd like to take a few minutes to see how each of you is feeling about the group so far, what you think has been helpful, and what other topics or issues you'd like to discuss. To do this, I'd like people

to pair up for about 2 minutes and then come back to share your thoughts. *(The leader pairs up the members, pairing herself with Sally. She learns that Sally is worried about how other members might view her because she has continued to live with her abusive, alcoholic husband. The leader reassures Sally that she will not let the members attack her and that it might be helpful if Sally shared some of her concerns before the session ended. Sally agrees. The leader ends the dyads and brings the group together again.)* I'd like each of us to share our thoughts about the group.

CARME: The group has been good for me to just get things off my mind.

BILL: Jack and I talked about what it was like to have alcoholic wives. I feel relieved just knowing other people are in the same boat.

LEADER: Sally shared some of her fear about talking about her family situation in the group. We both agreed it would be helpful for her to talk a little about that before we stop.

SALLY: It's real scary for me to be here. I feel I contributed to my husband's drinking by trying to cover it up.

CARME: I feel the same way—I hope we can talk about this at the next meeting.

The leader knew it was important for this quiet member to "break the ice" with the group before the end of this session so that she and the other members would begin to feel comfortable with one another.



Members Summarize A simple way to close the session is to have one or more members summarize what has transpired. The leader can ask for a volunteer to summarize or may select a member who would do a good job. If one member summarizes, other members may also be given the opportunity to add what they feel is important. The leader may also want to add any important events that were overlooked by the members. During the closing phase, a summary should not be long or boring. The purpose is to give the members a brief review. Following the summary, members may wish to comment on particular points that were especially important to them.

Leader Summarizes The leader may choose to summarize the session. By doing this, the leader can emphasize certain points and focus on certain members' comments. The disadvantage is that the leader may forget something that was important to one or two members; this may result in those members feeling hurt or resentful. To prevent this, the leader may find it helpful to let members contribute additional summaries following the leader's summary.

Written Reactions There are several ways the leader can use written reactions during the closing phase (Riordan & White, 1996). The leader can begin the closing phase of a session by asking members to write their reactions to the session.

LEADER: It's about 8:45. Let's summarize and close the group. First, I'd like you to spend a few minutes jotting down any reactions, thoughts, or feelings regarding the session tonight. We'll then share some of those thoughts and stop by 9:00.

Writing can be helpful for those members who respond more comfortably after having had a chance to put their ideas on paper. Members can also write for 5 to 10 minutes at the very end, when the group has completed the closing. The journal can be left with the leader, who then has an opportunity to read the members' reactions. The leader may choose to write encouraging or clarifying comments in the journals and then return them to the members at the next session.

The journal also provides each member with a lasting chronicle of the entire group experience from the first to the final session.

Helpful Closing Skills and Techniques

Clarity of Purpose The leader needs to be very clear as to the purpose of the closing phase. A variety of issues and concerns may be raised by members during the closing phase that can take the group in unproductive or new directions. When members bring up new topics, the leader needs to explain the purpose of the closing phase and offer the option of bringing the topics up at the beginning of the next session. The important thing to remember during the closing phase of a group session is that the session is ending.

Cutting Off To maintain the necessary focus on closing, the leader must be ready to use cutting-off skills. Members not only bring up new material during the closing phase but they often get into rehashing the session rather than highlighting or summarizing.

■ EXAMPLE

LEADER: What else did you learn from the session today?

LINDA: I'd like to know from the other girls if they have to go to church every Sunday. I do, and I hate it!

LEADER: *(In a warm, caring voice)* Linda, that seems like an important issue for you, but we really do not have time to get into a new topic right now. If you will bring that up at the next session, we'll certainly talk about it.

In this example, the leader stops other members from answering by speaking first. She does so to make sure that a new topic does not get started during the closing phase.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Closing a Group—Preventing a New Topic

Go to video 15.3 and watch the segment where the leader uses cutting off in order to prevent a new topic from being introduced during the closing phase.

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Tying Together The skill of tying together is especially beneficial during the closing phase of a session. By using this skill, the leader can create a sense of interrelatedness of themes, issues, and personal experiences. It is important for the leader to identify those points that relate to one another and then share them in such a way that the members see how patterns, issues, and people are connected. This is something the members are often unable to do themselves.

Drawing Out Drawing out is also an important skill to use during the closing phase of a session because the leader usually wants to hear from as many members as possible. Several of the techniques for closing mentioned earlier—especially the use of writing, dyads, and rounds—facilitate the drawing-out process. It is especially important for the leader to draw out members who are less active during the session, both to help them feel involved and to get their reactions to the session.

Wishes A useful technique for closing certain kinds of growth, support, and therapy sessions is the use of "wishes." This activity helps build positive and supportive feelings among members.

■ EXAMPLE

LEADER: I think that pretty much summarizes the session. Any comments? *(Pause—no one seems ready to comment.)* Let's do this. *(Speaking slowly)* Look around the room and see if there is anyone you have a wish for. If there is someone, identify the person and then say, "My wish for you is...." For example, Joe, my wish for you is that you will call your parents and say those things that you want to say. No one has to offer a wish and many may not receive a wish but I do think some of you will have wishes for other members.

MAX: Don, my wish for you is that you get out at least twice this week.

JOE: Cherry, my wish for you is that you will stop blaming yourself.

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GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Closing a Group—Use of Wishes

Go to video 15.2 and watch the segment where the leader uses the technique of "My Wish for You."

Acknowledging a New Member The leader may want to vary the closing slightly when a member is present for the first time. The leader might want to allow some extra time during the closing phase to focus on the new member if the member seems to feel comfortable enough but has been relatively quiet. Focusing on the new member gives that member a chance to share, which can help her feel even more comfortable. It also gives members a chance to know a little more about her. By hearing from the new member, the leader also has a better idea of how that person is feeling about being in the group.

EXAMPLE

Two members have finished summarizing the session, and others have commented.

LEADER: Connie (*the new member*), I hope this has been interesting and maybe even helpful.

CONNIE: Well, I was really nervous for the first 10 minutes, but I did relax. I am sorry that I didn't say more, but I really don't like talking in front of groups. I hope it will get easier for me.

LEADER: Was the session helpful?

CONNIE: Oh, yes. I already realize that others have feelings similar to mine.

LEADER: I hope that during the next session you will feel free to share. Anyone else have any closing thoughts before we stop?

Acknowledging a Member Who Is Leaving There are occasions when a member leaves a group even though the group continues. In a closed group, members may drop out for any variety of reasons. More often, the departure of one member occurs in an ongoing, open-membership group, such as residential treatment programs in substance abuse or physical rehabilitation centers. Members leave the group because they are going home or somewhere else.

When a member is leaving, it is important that the leader allows some time during the closing to focus on that member. The leader may get the member to review his goals upon entrance to the group and the progress he has made, have the members provide encouragement and feedback, and say good-bye. Although the exiting member is the major focal point, the leader may wish

to use this experience to help other members think about when they will be leaving the group and what they still need to do to get themselves ready for leaving.

The amount of time that should be given to a member who is exiting depends on the length of time of the session, the purpose of the group, and the kind of member he has been. In open-ended groups, members may be exiting fairly often, so the time devoted to a leaving member must be monitored. It is important not to devote most of the session to the departing member because this could mean that every session or two would be focused on departing members rather than those who are in the group. To say goodbye to the exiting member, 5 to 10 minutes is usually sufficient.

EXAMPLES

LEADER: We have about 20 minutes left in the session, so I would like to begin to summarize the session. Also, I want to leave the last few minutes free to focus on Walt, who will be leaving the group after today. I want each of you to think of the one thing that stood out for you today. *(Pause)* Mike, you seem ready.

MIKE: The discussion about the importance of not keeping our feelings inside was really helpful.

ANDY: The thing that stood out for me was ...

LEADER: *(After spending time completing the round and processing the session)* Okay, let's spend a few minutes saying goodbye to Walt. Most of you have known Walt for a while now. I want you to think of how you see Walt now compared to when he first entered the group. We'll share that and then we'll share any wishes that we have for him. How is Walt different?

MARIO: He is really different. *(To Walt)* When you first came into the group, you didn't talk or even look up. I really do think the program has helped you.

LEADER: I agree. You really have changed. I see you as a lot more open and that chip on your shoulder seems to be gone.

CARL: That's right! You did have a chip on your shoulder those first two meetings. It's gone.

LEADER: *(After others have shared)* If you had a wish for Walt, what would that be?

JEFF: My wish is that you have that conversation with your wife that you practiced in here.

BRUNO: My wish is that you don't let that chip come back. The soft, gentle side is much nicer.

LEADER: *(After two other members have shared wishes)* Walt, what thoughts or reactions or closing comments do you have for the group?

WALT: Well, I appreciate all your support. I also want to say ...

In this example, the exiting member got a chance to hear some good and encouraging feedback.

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There are times when a departing member has not really used the group or the treatment program that much. In this case, the leader may want to focus on feedback and wishes, in the hope that something might be said that will help.

LEADER: In saying goodbye to Sharon, I want each of you to think of what you believe will be the roughest thing for Sharon to handle when she goes home.

PAUL: I really think that Sharon is going to have trouble.

LEADER: Instead of talking to me, could you address Sharon?

PAUL: Sure. Sharon, I think you are going to have trouble with a lot of things, because you still seem angry at your parents.

BIFF: Sharon, I think you are fooling yourself when you say that you can make it without going to AA meetings. I hope your pride will not keep you from calling someone for help.

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In this example, the leader wants to make sure that the member is not attacked, because she is leaving that afternoon. At the same time, he is hoping that someone says something that will be helpful, because Sharon really does not seem ready to leave the program.

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Alerting Members to Reactions Outside of Group

Although the group experience can generate strong feelings among members, the leader should explain to the members that they will probably not experience the same kind of sharing with people outside of group (such as at work, home or with family), and this is normal. During the session, members often share at a very personal level, take risks, and experience warm, caring acceptance. They may go home and want to experience the same thing with their spouse, parents, friends, or coworkers. When this does not occur, some members become angry, frustrated, or resentful at the people in their lives or the leader of the group. Leaders should be aware that members may actually

feel closer to other members of the group than a spouse, children, or long-term friends. The leader should always be sensitive to this occurrence and bring it up in group if it seems to be a problem.

LEADER: I want to say something now, and I will probably say it again in our last session. Many of you are really opening up and sharing with the group, and I think it is great. Also, the way you are responding to what is being said is terrific. I think nearly everyone is experiencing good feelings as a result of being here. For many of you, these feelings are unique, and I want to caution you about going home and trying to share like this with your spouse and friends. Remember, they have not been in this group and have not had this experience. If you want this kind of sharing, give them time. Don't expect them to be able to do this immediately. Also, realize that they may never be able to do exactly what we are doing here.

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Handling Criticism of the Session

The leader should be prepared for criticism about the session or the group during the closing of the session. The leader must not be defensive. In most cases, the leader will not want the closing to be spent entirely on criticism unless he senses that the majority of the members are having the same feelings. The way the leader handles the criticism will depend on the kind of criticism, the merit of the criticism, and the amount of time needed for the actual closing. The following are several ways the leader can handle criticism during the closing phase.

■ EXAMPLES

Melvin is a member who has tried to dominate the group, and the leader has had to cut him off on numerous occasions. The leader has a strong sense from the members' nonverbal responses that they appreciate the fact that Melvin is not allowed to dominate.

MELVIN: *(In a hostile voice)* I have something I want to say. I feel you control too much. In other groups, the leader hardly said anything—this is more your group than our group!

LEADER: *(To Melvin and the entire group)* I do hope you feel that this is your group. There are times when I direct what is happening simply because I am trained as a counselor and a group leader. And, as I said earlier, there will be times when I may cut you off to hold the focus on another issue or when it seems like you have gotten a little long-winded. Certainly, I do not want you to feel that I am dominating the group.

Does anyone else feel that way? *(No one responds.)* Let's go back to summarizing the session. Other thoughts or reactions?

In this example, the leader briefly responded, got support from the members, and then went back to closing the group.

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LEADER: Who else wants to comment on what stood out to them?

JAMES: I feel like the group gets too personal. When Pete was talking, I felt you really pushed him too hard!

LEADER: James, let me answer that. *(Looking at the entire group)* The group is personal, and I do push members hard because all of you have problems that need to be dealt with on more than a superficial level. Certainly, I try not to push you *too* hard, but do realize that not dealing with your problems is what got you into the hospital.

PETE: I'm glad you pushed. I think I understand why I get so angry.

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The leader has been feeling that the group has not gone well the last couple of sessions.

JOSÉ: I don't mean to be critical, but the group has not been very valuable for me lately.

LEADER: How do others of you feel? I, too, think something is missing.

RUSTY: I would like us to be more personal rather than just discussing things. Does anyone else feel that way?

PAM: I do. The discussions about legal issues, custody, and so on are all good, but there are personal things that I think I am ready to share.

PAUL: I would like that better.

LEADER: So what you are saying is that you would like this to be more of a sharing group than a discussion/education group. How about the rest of you, how do you feel?

In this example, the leader decided to focus on the criticism because she felt that the group did perhaps need a new emphasis.

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Final Thoughts on Closing a Session

The leader who successfully closes a group session enhances the value of the session considerably. Without an effective closing, many important issues discussed during the session may become blurred or lost. The closing phase requires thought and planning. If done well, members come away with a sense of

completeness. Effective session closing can also help build cohesiveness, because members get to hear others' reactions.

The Closing Stage

Perhaps the most important point to remember when preparing for the closing stage of a group is that the group is not an entity in itself, but a collection of individuals. When the group is over, the individuals go away, taking with them new information, insights, decisions, or beliefs that make everyday living happier and more productive. The leader's task during the closing stage is to focus on these benefits.

Time Allowed for the Closing Stage

The amount of time allowed to complete the closing stage of a group depends on the kind of group, its purpose, the number of sessions, and the members' needs. As a general rule, the greater the number of sessions and the more personal the sharing, the longer the closing stage. For example, in a therapy group meeting for 2 hours weekly for 15 sessions, the leader might begin the closing stage toward the middle of the fourteenth session, because there will be a considerable amount to cover. In contrast, a task group working on improving a residential treatment program for drug abusers and meeting an hour each week for four sessions may require only 15 minutes of the last session for the closing stage. The closing stage of education and discussion groups would usually not take more than 10 to 20 minutes of the last session. Similarly, a children's self-concept group meeting for 40 minutes a week for five sessions may take only 10 to 15 minutes of the last session for closing. Although it is possible that the closing stage could take two or more sessions, part of the last session is usually enough time for closing.

Purpose and Goals of the Closing Stage

The purpose of the closing stage is to pull together the significant ideas, decisions, and personal changes experienced by the members during the group. This is a time for members to look at their progress in the group and to compare their goals at the start of the group with their accomplishments at the end. While the leader may focus to some extent on the dynamics of the group itself (such as how the members have interacted or how they have helped each other), the main focus for most groups will be on each member's growth and development. The following are the several tasks of the closing stage.

1. Reviewing and summarizing the group experience
2. Assessing members' growth and change
3. Finishing business
4. Applying change to everyday life (implementing decisions)

5. Providing feedback
6. Handling goodbyes
7. Planning for continued problem resolution

Reviewing and Summarizing the Group Experience One of the first tasks during the closing stage of most groups is to review and summarize the significant developments of the group. The leader can accomplish the task of review and summary by: (1) summarizing the entire group, (2) getting members to summarize their experience, or (3) facilitating interaction that focuses on summarizing and reviewing. The first option can be used if there have not been many sessions and the leader remembers most of the significant events. If the group has met for a number of sessions, this might not be the best option because the leader may not remember some important topics or discussions. The second option, having the members summarize their experiences, can be valuable if the group is small and the summaries can be kept to 2 to 3 minutes each. If the group is large (10 or more), this is not usually a good option, because it would probably take too much time and become repetitious. The third option, which allows members to share what has stood out to them, is usually best.

EXAMPLE

It is the final session of a high school growth group.

LEADER: Because this is the last session, I want to spend the remainder of our time reviewing the group experience and how it has affected you. First, I want you to think of three things that stood out to you during the sessions. What discussions, exercises, or comments do you remember the most? *(Pause)* Sandi, you seem ready.

SANDI: The discussion about my mom and how I can deal with her better than I do. Focusing on the difference between being assertive and being aggressive was helpful. A third thing would be the discussion about taking risks to get more out of life.

PHILIPPE: The discussion concerning risk taking was the highlight for me. I think about that every day.

LEADER: Let me ask—was that a major insight for some others of you?

ARMAND: It was number one on my list, too. Whenever I am bored or afraid, I think over what risks I can take or remember that it is okay to be afraid when I am trying something new.

In this example, having members share what was important and periodically holding the focus on various topics is an excellent way to bring the group to a close.

Assessing Members' Growth and Change This task applies to groups such as therapy groups, where the primary purpose is personal growth or change. By the time the closing stage rolls around, members should have experienced the implementation of some changes in their lives. One problem that members face when the group meetings end is that members may return to their former, less effective ways of living. It is important for the leader to highlight this potential problem for members and to reinforce their efforts to maintain positive change. This can be done, in part, by getting members to evaluate their success in making changes. This assessment reinforces the changes and encourages members to pursue further growth and development.

EXAMPLE

The group is in the closing stage of a personal growth experience in a university counseling center.

LEADER: Since this is our last session, I think it might be helpful if each of you spent a few minutes looking at the changes you have brought about in your lives during these past 10 weeks. Some of you are more aware of your values and what you want to get from your life; others of you brought problems or concerns that you resolved through the group, and so forth. Take a minute and think about the important changes you've experienced in the group. When you are ready, I'm going to ask you to share those thoughts with the group.

This sharing can lead to feedback from other members, encouragement, and plans for continued work on issues following the end of the group.

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Finishing Business During the closing stage, it is common to have a few loose ends that still need to be tied up before the members can comfortably leave the group. It is important for the leader to allow time for this because unfinished business can interfere with the sense of closure and may leave one or more members with unresolved issues. Following are some examples of unfinished business that might come up during the closing stage:

- An issue or question that was brought up in a previous session but never dealt with
- Negative feelings about how the leader handled a particular situation during a session
- A question a member has for another member or for the leader
- A member needing to work on some unresolved personal issue

Although it is important to assess and handle unfinished business, the leader must be careful not to generate new business. For example, if a member

expresses some dissatisfaction with how the leader handled a particular situation during an earlier session, the leader may simply want to accept the statement rather than get into a lengthy explanation or discussion. If a member wants or needs therapy on an unresolved issue, the leader may choose to refer the member for counseling or see the member after the session. Delving into new issues is seldom appropriate for the closing stage.

The following is an example of how a leader might introduce the topic of unfinished business.

LEADER: One thing that is important to do during this closing is to allow some time for any unfinished group business that needs to be dealt with. I am not asking for personal work issues because we are trying to close the group. If there is something that you want to say or ask, please do so. I urge you not to leave thinking, "I wish I had said this or that."

Applying Changes to Everyday Life (Implementing Decisions)

Discussing how the members are going to continue to implement the changes that they have made is valuable. By talking about applying the changes in the group to their everyday lives, members can be reminded of how far they have come and what they still need to do to become the person they want to be. This applies especially to in-patient groups or treatment centers where they don't get to apply the changes to their "real" lives.

Providing Feedback During the closing stage, some final feedback to members is often helpful. Members should be given a chance to comment to one another about the changes each has made. Such reinforcement should be sincere and as specific as possible. The leader should monitor the type of feedback given to make sure it is on target.

LEADER: Let's spend a few minutes thinking of positive changes that you have seen in other members. I'd like you to pick three people who you feel have made some positive changes. I'll ask you to tell each person what the change is and how you think the change is helpful for the person. For example, Alan, I feel that you are much friendlier, and it is now much easier to talk with you.

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LEADER: I want you to think about feedback that you feel would be helpful to give other members. You may want to think about changes that you have seen in members or thank them for something they said or did during a session.

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Feedback can also be given to confront members who are still denying problems or who have not taken responsibility for their behavior. Such feedback, when given honestly and without anger or disappointment, can have an impact on a member who seems unwilling to face certain unresolved issues. Feedback may be given by the leader, the members, or both.

■ EXAMPLE

In a drug treatment group, a member who is still denying that his continued use of drugs is having a negative effect on his family life may benefit greatly from feedback sincerely given by the other members of the group.

SAM: Dave, even though you are fooling your family, your therapist, and even yourself by your continued use of drugs, you are not fooling us, because we've been there.

ANN: I agree, Dave, you really have to stop thinking that you don't have a problem. Face it, you have a drug problem! Even though this group is ending, I do hope you will decide to really get help.

In this example, the members can probably have more impact than the leader, because they are seen as peers who have struggled and dealt with a similar problem. In other situations, the leader is better able to give confrontive or negative feedback because he sees aspects of a member's behavior that the members do not see or because he knows the member better from having worked with him on an individual basis.

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Handling Goodbyes It is important for the leader to remember that for many members, the ending of a group is the end of a very special event in their lives. The relationships formed in the group may be the closest relationships some members have ever experienced. For most members, this will go smoothly. However, for some, the ending of the group will elicit anxiety over separating from the others. The positive effect of the group may be lessened if the leader does not identify and deal with those feelings. Clues to such feelings might be found in statements from members like these:

- I couldn't sleep last night because I knew today would be our last meeting.
- I feel like this is my second family, and I don't want to leave it.
- I don't think I can make it without this group.

When the leader hears these comments, the first task is to help members realize that these feelings are normal and allow them to express their feelings of sadness or loss. Second, the leader might want to point out that the kind of sharing and closeness members feel toward one another need not be unique, although the

positive sharing may have been a new experience. Also, if the leader knows that some members are going to have a tough time with the ending of the group, he may allow additional time during the closing stage to work with those members. Members sometimes wish to exchange telephone numbers and addresses if they have not done so already.

Planning for Follow-Up Care During the closing stage, it is the leader's responsibility to provide guidance, information, and the names and phone numbers of referral sources for any member who needs to continue working on personal concerns. Members must learn to employ their new information and knowledge about themselves with people in their daily lives. This is especially important for group members who have been clients in a residential treatment program for a period of time. Some members, such as those who have had addiction problems, need continued support and monitoring in the community. Many communities have a variety of support groups available either as independent organizations or through mental health centers, hospitals, or rehabilitation programs. The leader should include a discussion of the value of these groups during the closing stage.

In some types of groups, members may form support networks of their own to ensure continued reinforcement of one another, and they may plan "booster" meetings periodically to report on their progress. The need for this type of follow-up should be assessed by the leader in conjunction with the members. The entire group may be involved in the network, or members may choose one or more persons with whom to network. For members who ordinarily have difficulty developing and maintaining relationships, networking is very beneficial. Networking may also be a temporary measure for members who are new to a community or who have simply lost social contacts because of addictions or other problems. In some groups, time may be provided during the closing stage to develop individual plans for each member.

Exercises to Use During the Closing Stage

Rounds Rounds can be especially helpful during the closing stage. The round can be used to summarize key points, get overall reactions to the group or a particular experience, or check the degree to which members feel they accomplished personal goals. The leader might introduce closing rounds with one of the following questions:

- On a 1–10 scale, with 10 being very satisfied, how satisfied are you with your progress during this group?
- If you had to capture how you feel about your group experience in a sentence or two, what would you say? We'll do a round and hear from everyone.
- Because this is the last session, what is a word or phrase that expresses how you are feeling about the group ending?

Wishes The wishes exercise provides a special type of feedback for members during the closing stage. We gave an example of this earlier for the closing phase, but it is also an excellent activity for the closing stage.

■ EXAMPLE

It is the last session of a support group for recently divorced persons.

LEADER: Let's take the next few minutes and see if there are any wishes you might have for one another. You may or may not have a wish. It's okay either way. I have a wish for Darlene. My wish for you is that you will be able to let go of your angry feelings toward your husband and get on with your life.

DARLENE: Thank you.

BILL: My wish for you, Jane, is that you realize your teenagers are old enough to help out around the house and that you can stop being their slave.

JOSEFA: I have a wish for you too, Jane. My wish for you is that you take a chance. You won't know whether you can build a new relationship if you don't try.

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Reunion Fantasy An excellent exercise to use in closing certain personal growth, support, counseling, and therapy groups is the reunion fantasy. The purpose of this exercise is to get members to project their lives into the future. Many members are startled to find that in their fantasies, they have the power to bring about significant changes. They are encouraged by this imagining process and gain confidence that their lives can change for the better. Conversely, members are also surprised to find that they are unable to imagine some of the changes they have worked for in the group. They realize the need for a greater commitment to change and that they must take more responsibility for their lives if change is to come about.

LEADER: I'd like you to relax. Close your eyes if that is comfortable for you. I want you to imagine that the time is 5 years from now; you have just gone to the mailbox and have received a letter from me inviting you back for a group reunion. In the letter, I explain that I have received a grant to cover all expenses. Now that you have decided to attend, I want you to think of what you will tell the other members about your life and any changes. Think about where you are living, with whom you are living, what you are doing, and any significant events that have occurred. *(The leader pauses to allow the members to experience the fantasy.)* What do you most want to say to the other members about your life now? In a minute, I am going to ask you to stand up and act

like you are just seeing these people for the first time in 5 years, unless you remained in contact with some of them. Try to get into the role of having been apart for 5 years. *(Pause)* Okay, everyone open your eyes, stand, and start milling and sharing.

This exercise can be very thought-provoking for members who have come to know each other very well. As with all exercises, this one must be tailored to the kind of group, its purpose, and the needs of the members as they experience the group coming to an end. This exercise would be good to use during the beginning part of the closing stage, because it would get members to think about the group ending and the issues and changes they have talked about in the group. (It can also be used during the middle stage of a group if the leader wants to get members to focus on the future and possible changes.)

Members Writing About Their Experience The leader may provide a chance for members to write about some aspect of the group, either in their journals (if journals were used) or on paper provided. The members may write on a variety of topics: four or five things they learned, the most helpful experience for them during the group, personal goals at the beginning of the group and the extent to which each was achieved, and how decisions they made in the group will be applied outside the group. The leader may then have members share their written thoughts in pairs, small groups, or with the entire group. If the topic the members write about is lengthy or complex, the leader may ask each member to underline two or three key passages to share with the entire group to save time and maintain the focus. When using journals, members may also review their journal entries from all the previous sessions and write a summary paragraph that pulls together the key points of the group for them.

Using the Flipchart or Handouts An excellent tool for reviewing, summarizing, and consolidating information is a flipchart or whiteboard. The flipchart can be used to list points during the review and can be referred to as those points are discussed. It also serves as an excellent focal point for the members, as they continually gaze at the flipchart and thus stay focused on the review. Writing on the flipchart also gives members a chance to have direct input into the review and summarizing process.

Handouts are a variation on the flipchart technique. They differ primarily in that the leader has already summarized the key points. The advantage of the handout is that it saves time and gets the members focused on the discussion immediately. A handout may be particularly useful with discussion, education, and task groups, because the leader can often easily summarize the various key points.

Additional Considerations for the Closing Stage

As the leader plans the closing stage of the group, there are a number of points to think about. Not every kind of group requires consideration of all these factors. It is the leader's responsibility to determine which of these considerations are relevant.

1. Guarding against ending with strong emotions
2. Conducting exit interviews
3. Holding follow-up sessions
4. Evaluating the group
5. Ending with a party

Guarding Against Ending with Strong Emotions When closing a group where members have gotten very close, the leader will want to pay close attention to the emotional tone. The members may experience the ending as a very sad, intense, or extra-special event. If possible, these kinds of feelings should be avoided. Members should ideally see the ending as a new beginning, feeling positive about the group experience and excited about their future. The first example that follows depicts a leader talking about sad feelings regarding the ending of the group. The second example depicts a leader talking about the possibilities of ending on a "high."

EXAMPLES

LEADER: When we stop today, I know you might feel sad since this is the last group session. I hope you will realize that you can continue with the things you have learned in this group. I purposely will try to have us end with good feelings and not sadness, because I feel the group really has been a good experience for all of us. It has helped members to share and care, and I hope you have already started to create the same kind of sharing with significant others in your life.

The leader can prevent the false high phenomenon by presenting a positive yet calm attitude. To avoid ending on the "high," with much hugging and joyous crying, you might try to end groups that have been very close and personal by saying something like this:

LEADER: *(In a soft, rather neutral voice)* We are going to stop now. I do think the whole experience has been good, and the closing has been very good. I think you have had enough time to say what you wanted and to start a new beginning for yourself. If I can ever be of help, please feel free to contact me. I certainly have found the experience to be a good one. I think it is time to end.

Conducting Exit Interviews Earlier in this book, we discussed the value of interviewing potential group members before a group begins to establish rapport and exchange expectations about the group experience. There is also value in conducting exit interviews with members as the group enters the closing stage. Exit interviews are not needed in all groups; the leader must consider the value

of such interviews with regard to the kind of group and the needs of individual members. If exit interviews are conducted, they should last from 10 to 20 minutes. We suggest that they take place either before the final session of the group or very soon after the last session. The reason for meeting before the last session is that the leader can suggest how the member might use the closing stage to her benefit, such as requesting additional feedback from other members. The exit interview can also be a time for the leader to reinforce the gains a member has made, as well as to focus more individual attention on ways the member can apply those gains to everyday living. The interview further gives the leader a chance to ask for feedback about the group and various aspects of his leadership. Depending on the kind of group, some members may feel more comfortable giving the leader feedback on a one-to-one basis.

Holding Follow-Up Sessions The leader may consider holding a follow-up session of the group several weeks or months after the final regular session. The decision to have one or more follow-up meetings depends on the kind of group and the members' needs. For example, members of a task group who work together in the same organization may wish to have a follow-up session to assess how things are going. With some support or counseling groups, follow-up sessions give members a chance to share how they are doing and lessen the anxiety of separation. The leader may set up a formal follow-up program where members are notified and encouraged to return for a meeting. Occasionally, members decide they want to plan for a reunion in 6 months. This decision usually arises from the good feelings members have toward one another during the closing stage.

Experience suggests that these reunions are usually not very successful, because the feelings fade as time passes and members become involved in their own lives. If a reunion is planned, the leader should not feel disappointed by a small turnout, and members should be prepared for the experience to be very different from when they were meeting regularly.

One unique follow-up procedure that we use is to have members write themselves letters in which they assess their goals, give themselves feedback, and list plans for the future. The letters are given to the leader in a self-addressed, stamped envelope and are then mailed several weeks or months after the group has ended. Members have reported that this technique is powerful.

They say that writing the letter is thought-provoking, and knowing that it will come in the mail someday causes them to keep working even after the group has ended. Others have said that often their letter arrived at a good time, because they needed a "booster shot." The letter exercise is designed for use in a personal growth, counseling, or therapy group, but it could also be used with a task group as a way for members to check on the degree to which they have followed through on their decisions.

Evaluating the Group When any group ends, the leader must decide how she will evaluate the experience. Groups can be evaluated formally, with a questionnaire, or informally, with the leader asking specific questions during the closing stage. No matter how the evaluation is done, the leader should seek answers to the following questions:

- How valuable was the experience? (The leader could use a 1–10 scale.)
- What did members like about the group?
- What did members dislike about the group?
- What did members like about the way the leader led the group?
- What did members dislike about the way the leader led the group?
- How could the group have been better?

These are just the basic questions that should be asked. Certainly a more elaborate questionnaire could be devised that asked about specific topics, exercises, and events that occurred during the group. We encourage leaders, especially beginning leaders, to evaluate any group they lead. The responses and comments from their members can be very helpful in leading future groups.

Ending with a Party Often members want to end the group with a party. They may suggest meeting at someone's house or meeting for pizza. The leader should give a good deal of thought to such a request; often, when the group meets in another setting, a group session never really takes place and thus no real closing occurs. If the leader and the group decide to meet in a setting like this, the leader will want to tell members ahead of time that the first hour or so will be devoted to closing the group.

A variation of this is for the group to plan a party to be held after the group has officially ended. Sometimes this type of party works fine, and other times it does not work out very well. We suggest that the leader at least prepare members for the possibility that the party may not go well.

Concluding Comments

The *closing phase* is a very important phase of a session and is often mishandled because the leader has not managed the time of the session very well. The closing phase serves the purpose of reviewing a session and ensuring that members leave feeling reasonably "finished." When a leader fails to plan for the closing phase, closing is either hurried or skipped, causing the members to leave with no closure. It is very important to have a closing phase to each session.

The *closing* stage of a group is the last stage—it is when the group is winding down and preparing to stop meeting. The closing stage is usually a portion of the last session, the entire last session, or perhaps, the last two sessions. Its purpose is to bring closure to the experience.

The closing phase and the closing stage are each very important aspects of a group because they allow members to review what has happened and to commit to what they are going to do in the future. Also, closing is an important time for reflecting on the group, and giving and receiving feedback. During the closing stage, it is important for the members to assess their progress, evaluate the experience, and discuss follow-up support.

There are a number of skills, techniques, and exercises that are useful during closing. Rounds are very helpful because they tend to get everyone to speak, and it is important to hear reactions from the quieter members. Writing as a part of closing has proved to be quite valuable for many different kinds of groups. Cutting off is essential because members tend to tell stories or bring up new topics.

ACTIVITIES

1. Think back to group experiences or classes that you had where there was no time for closing. What did it feel like to have the experience just end? What would have made the ending better for you?
2. List the skills and techniques you plan to use in the closing phase and stage of groups that you will be leading in the future.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

View again the three videos (15.1, 15.2, 15.3) showing closing in a group, and think about different directions the group could have gone if the leader had not had closing skills. Also think of some other ways these groups could have been closed.